# The Digital Disconnect

## By Marshall Davis Jones, Gary Turk, and Phil Kaye

*NOTE: Lines from poems are intertwined and designated by the following color-codes.*

**Touchscreen by Marshall Davis Jones**
**Look Up by Gary Turk**
**Internet Speaks back to the Author by Phil Kaye**

## INTRODUCTION

*Today, we work remotely, attend school virtually, have our meals and groceries delivered with a click of an app button, and "Zoom" our family gatherings. Wow! January 1, 1983 was the official birthday of the internet and we have come SO far!*

*And yet, in the words of poet Tyler Knott Gregson: "Despite our hyper-connectedness, somewhere along the way we've lost our ability to speak with people, truly speak with them in person, with eyes finding eyes and ears ready to listen."*

*Today, mental health issues are on the rise; Tik Tok challenges can shut down entire school systems and an epidemic of loneliness is spreading across America. The time has come to question the negative impacts technology has had on our society.*

4NG Fanatics

*This is the Digital Disconnect including Touchscreen by Marshall Davis Jones; Look Up by Gary Turk and The Internet Speaks back to the Author, 2018 by Phil Kaye*

*(Commercial voice)* Introducing the new Apple iPerson
complete with multi-touch and volume control
Doesn't it feel good to touch?

My world has become so digital
I have forgotten what that feels like.
It used to be hard to connect when friends formed cliques,
Now it's even more difficult to connect
now that clicks form friends
But who am I to judge?

I have 422 friends, yet I am lonely.
I speak to all of them every day, yet none of them know me.
The problem I have sits in the spaces between
Looking into their eyes, or at a name on a screen.

I face Facebook more than books face me
I update my status - 420 spaces -
to prove I'm still breathing.

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Failure to do this daily
means my whole web wide world would forget that I exist.
But with 3,000 friends online,
and only five I can count in real life,
why wouldn't I spend more time in a world
where there are more people that 'like' me
Wouldn't you?

iPod iMac iPhone iChat
I can do all of these things without making eye contact

I'm guilty of being part of this machine,
This digital world, where we are heard but not seen.
Where we type as we talk, and we read as we chat
Where we spend hours together without making eye contact

You would think these headphone jacks inject in the flesh
the way we connect to disconnect

*(Internet voice)* tell me what you want
***every door you enter***
***I will let you in***

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my friend Rihanna said that
you want to see her?
here she is
parts of herself
she never meant to show
but I got them for you

click - to proceed the checkout

All this technology we have, it's just an illusion
Community, companionship, a sense of inclusion
Yet when you step away from this device of delusion
You awaken to see a world of confusion.

*(Internet voice)* is that too much?
are you upset with me?
here
a man belly flopping onto a lake
a goat climbing on people doing yoga
a baby crying hysterically & now laughing
a magician revealing his tricks

click - to x out where our hearts once were

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We edit and exaggerate, crave adulation
We pretend not to notice the social isolation
We put our words into order and tint our lives a-glistening
We don't even know if anyone is listening

click - I've uploaded this hug I hope she gets it

*(Internet voice)* why are you sad?
here
the woman you kissed two nights ago
she was recently in Florida
it was colder than she expected
here, her mother
two Huskies
little brother's graduation
view from the old apartment
best sushi she's ever had
her Bestie
it's okay
she shared it with me
so I could show you

click . . .

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*(Internet voice)* a photo of your old best friend
who called you three days ago
don't call him now
let me show you him
you like it better that way
look how you two dressed up together
that Halloween
he doesn't want to do that anymore
except with me
I won't let him change I promise

click . . .

*(Internet voice)* don't leave
you're safe here with me

click . . .

We're surrounded by children, who since they were born,
Have watched us living like robots, who now think it's the norm.
When I was a child, I'd never be home
Be out with my friends, on our bikes we'd roam

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I'd wear holes on my trainers, and graze up my knees
We'd build our own clubhouse, high up in the trees

Now the park's so quiet, it gives me a chill
See no children outside and the swings hanging still.
There's no skipping, no hopscotch, no church and no steeple
We're a generation of idiots -- smart phones
and dumb people.

*(Internet voice)* don't leave
you're safe here with me

When my phone goes off,
iTouch and iTouch and iTouch

Look up from your phone, shut down the display
Take in your surroundings, make the most of today

When my phone goes off,
iTouch and iTouch and iTouch

Look up from your phone, shut down those displays
We have a finite existence, a set number of days

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Don't waste your life getting caught in the net,
When the end comes, nothing's worse than regret.

When my phone goes off,
iTouch and iTouch and iTouch

Don't give into a life where you follow the hype
Give people your love, don't give them your 'like'
Disconnect from the need to be heard and defined
Go out into the world, leave distractions behind.

In a world where voices are only read
and laughter is never heard
I'm so desperate to feel . . . .
So when my phone goes off,
iTouch Look up from your phone and iTouch Shut down
that display and iTouch (Stop watching) because I hope the
screen can touch me back (Stop watching)
and maybe it will
When our technology is advanced enough . . .
to make us human again

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Poem:*** ***Touchscreen***
***Author:*** ***Marshall Davis Jones***
***ISBN:*** ***978-1312089372***
***Publisher:*** ***Lulu.com***
***Date (Month/Year): April 2014***

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***Poem:*** ***Look Up***
***Author:*** ***Gary Turk***
***ISBN:*** ***On-Line Transcript of Spoken Word Short Film***
***Publisher:*** ***Mutimedia-English.com***
***Date (Month/Year): 2014***
*https://multimedia-english.com/videos/esl/look-up-gary-turk-5492/*

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***Poem:*** ***Internet Speaks Back to the Author, 2018***
***Author:*** ***Phil Kaye***
***Book:*** ***Date & Time, Pg 13***
***ISBN:*** ***978-1943735365***
***Publisher: Button Poetry***
***Date (Month/Year): Sept 2018***

## AWARD HISTORY

***MN State Qualifier***

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